Hip-Hop Mix Glue

Sounds like: a modern rap record — loud, controlled low end, vocal on top

ACCURACY B

Close enough to fool most ears.

NOT YET TESTED - settings are a starting point; trust your ears

WHAT YOU NEED (in this order)

`Master insert: MClass Equalizer -> MClass Stereo Imager -> MClass Compressor -> MClass Maximizer`

Starting material: balanced rough mix, 808 and vocal already sitting right

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DO THIS, STEP BY STEP

1. MClass EQ: Lo Cut OFF (you need the sub!). Param 1: if the 808 is wooly, cut 1–2 dB around 250 Hz. Hi shelf +1 dB at 12 kHz for expensive-sounding air.

2. MClass Stereo Imager: LOW band (below ~150 Hz) width toward mono. Mono bass hits harder everywhere and survives club systems. High band width +10–20%, no more.

3. MClass Compressor: ratio 2:1, slow attack, Adapt release, 1–2 dB reduction. Even in loud rap masters, bus glue stays gentle — loudness comes next, not here.

4. MClass Maximizer: this genre leans on it harder — 3–5 dB of limiting is normal. Look Ahead ON, output -0.3. Listen for 808 distortion; if the sub farts, the limiter is fighting the low end — go back to step 2 and mono/tame the bass more.

5. Volume-matched A/B against a commercial rap reference. Check on earbuds AND anything with a subwoofer: two different low-end realities, both have to work.

Why this works

Rap masters live or die on low-end management; every step here disciplines the sub before the limiter has to.

Why this order

Imager before compressor: mono-ing the bass changes energy the comp reacts to. Maximizer always dead last.

Reason trick

Save this whole master insert chain as a preset from the master section — every new song starts one click from your mastering baseline.

The skill you just learned

Loudness is earned upstream — a limiter reveals low-end problems, it doesn't solve them.

Worth buying?
For A: a modern true-peak limiter VST (many free/cheap) outperforms the 2004-era Maximizer at high limiting depths.